

PROLOGUE

Humble Beginnings, Ambitious Ends: Special Issue on Motivation and the Educational Process

To fully appreciate the content of this special issue of *Contemporary Educational Psychology*, expressly dedicated to the theme of motivation and education, it is helpful to understand its origins. As with many others, I became acutely aware of the growing presence and widening influence of motivation theory in educational research and practice, especially over the past decade. It is now difficult to pick up a research journal or scholarly volume that does not make reference to one or more motivation constructs. This increased awareness actually led me to reconceptualize my programs of research and to incorporate selected motivation variables in my empirical studies.

Despite this personal investment, and the resulting foothold in the motivation territory it afforded me, I nonetheless felt like an uncertain traveler. I was reminded of my efforts to use my “fraudulent” Italian on hapless residents of Florence. Indeed, in desperation, one kind gentleman, unable to contain himself, proclaimed, “You speak the language like a native, but you say nothing!” I am understandably determined not to reexperience such lexical embarrassment as I venture deeper into motivation territory. Thus, under the leadership of Karen Murphy, it was decided that an extensive review of motivation terminology, focused in the area of academic achievement, might be the answer. Such a review, we surmised, would provide us with the conceptual assurance we felt lacking. Our naïve intention was to end this review with a clear understanding of key motivation terms commonplace in the vernacular of this impressive research community. In effect, we hoped to speak the motivational language like a native—but this time intelligently.

Past experience had at least taught me that excursions into unknown territories are far less perilous and far more fruitful when expert guides blaze the trail. Consequently, even as Karen and I began the process of framing this literature review, we relied on the guidance of the friendly natives of the motivation domain to plot our course. These experts, many of whom

are participants in this special issue, suggested critical concepts, nominated important works, and even commented on an earlier draft.

Yet, upon the conclusion of our review, which opens this special issue, we found ourselves with as many questions about motivation terminology as we had when we set out—all be they more complex and sophisticated questions. It was evident that our humble attempts to journey deeper into the motivation literature had taken us in unexpected directions. As we reflected on the conclusions and implications we drew from this review, however, we soon realized that the issues and questions punctuating our thoughts were likely those that other educators, seeking entry into the motivation domain, would raise.

For this reason, we again turned to the experts in the field of motivation. This time we asked them to speak to the issues and questions about terminology that emerged from our foray into the achievement motivation literature. They graciously agreed. The platform for this initial exchange was a symposium at the 1998 American Educational Research Conference in San Diego. From the number of individuals who crowded into that session or stood outside in the hall, it was apparent that an examination of the relationship between motivation and the academic process was of tremendous interest to many educational researchers. Karen and I were clearly not alone in our desire to know more about central concepts from the achievement motivation literature. Thus, in this special issue, I set out to capture some of the themes that resulted from that session, as well as continuing discussions, and put them before the readership of *Contemporary Educational Psychology*.

I express my deep appreciation to Mike Royer for opening up the pages of *Contemporary Educational Psychology* for this exploration and to the developmental reviewers, themselves motivation experts, who helped sharpen the ideas and language in these articles. Of course, my greatest appreciation is reserved for the renowned experts in motivation who have contributed their insights and collective wisdom to this volume. Despite its humble beginnings as an exercise in self-enlightenment, I am hopeful that the outcome of this venture is a series of articles that clarify the language of achievement motivation and map that terrain for other travelers.

Patricia A. Alexander
Guest Editor